

Pre-Matriculation Prep Resources for Admitted Students

First and foremost, congratulations on your admission and welcome to Chicago Booth! We are excited to meet you on campus this fall, and we wanted to provide some resources for those of you interested in potentially pursuing an investment banking (IB) internship at Booth. These resources have been consolidated to help those of you in the following situations:

- You might be interested in investment banking, but you are not sure exactly what investment bankers do
- You intend to recruit for investment banking, and you have lots of time on your hands so want to begin preparing before getting to campus

If you are in one of these situations, we advise that you reference the following recommendations and resources over the summer as time allows.

Recommendations

Complete the [Career Services Canvas Course for the Class of 2028](#) this summer

[This course](#) helps you prepare for the career programs during Orientation and Pre-term, and in early autumn, before recruiting begins in early October. The course modules – Introduction to Career Services, Self-Assessment, Career Exploration and Research, Resume, Networking, Recruiting Planning & Preparation – in addition to this resource guide, are the first steps in preparing for investment banking internship recruiting.

Take inventory of impactful experiences for your “Why Banking” Story

Your “Why Banking” story is an incredibly important part of your recruiting process. It is effectively a resume walkthrough that draws a clear link between your past experiences and why you decided to recruit for investment banking. Your Story is recommended to be ~1 minute in length. One of the best things you can do before arriving on campus is to take inventory of what professional and non-professional (if applicable) experiences have contributed to your motivation to pursue a career in banking, and how these skills are transferable to investment banking. These experiences can include jobs, specific projects, previous education, etc. There is no need to fully create your “Why Banking” story before you arrive on campus but reflecting on your experiences ahead of time can be helpful. Start with these activities:

- Complete the [Self-Assessment assignments in Canvas](#)
- Complete the [Develop Your Career Focus assignment](#) in Canvas, using the [Exploring Careers](#) page content (choose the investment banking job description)
- Complete the [Networking & Story assignment](#) in Canvas.

You will update your draft story during Orientation and Pre-term. From there you will continue to workshop and refine your story throughout the recruiting process, with help from IBG, Career Advisors, and Career Coaches.

Research and begin following business news publications

We recommend that you browse the Wall Street Journal regularly, focusing particularly on articles applicable to the investment banking industry and industries you might be interested in covering as a banker. Reading industry-specific publications (CNET for tech, Bisnow for real estate, etc.) will be helpful as well.

Start thinking about your recruiting strategy

Watch the [Intro to MBA Recruiting video](#) for a high-level overview of the MBA recruiting process. Then review the [Investment Banking Intro to Internship Recruiting Guide](#) to get a preview of the recruiting process, including the recruiting timeline and a snapshot of the recruiting landscape. As you review the types of banks that recruit MBAs (e.g., bulge bracket, independent advisory, middle market), start thinking about your recruiting strategy. IBG suggests that you cast a wide net and recruit with as many banks as possible, but it is important to identify what kinds of banking and what geographies are the best fit and of most interest to you – the following two sections provide further guidance regarding these specific considerations.

Identify potential groups to target

There are many different types of investment banking groups, which can be broadly categorized as either coverage or product groups (see FAQs below for more detail on coverage vs product groups). Learning about different groups will help you determine which ones a) align best with your background and skills and b) seem most interesting to you. This will help you determine how to best allocate your time during the networking phase of the IBG process in the fall. The Mergers & Inquisitions [Investment Banking Industry Guide](#) is an outstanding resource that includes overviews of various types of investment banking groups in addition to other helpful information.

Identify which 1-2 geographies you want to target

There are several locations where you can recruit for a job in investment banking. Keep in mind that culture and the role you have as an investment banking associate varies across locations. It is difficult to successfully recruit for more than one geography (e.g., tech in San Francisco and New York) given that different geographies have different recruiting timelines. IBG and Career Services will coach you through choosing a geography as you develop your recruiting strategy, but it's good to start thinking about this now. Banks typically hire summer associates in these geographies: New York, NY; Chicago, IL; San Francisco/Bay Area, CA; Houston, TX. There is some hiring in Los Angeles, CA, Charlotte, NC, Richmond, VA, Minneapolis, MN, and Boston, MA as well. Hiring for international locations (e.g. London, Hong Kong) varies year to year, but is typically limited.

Update your resume to Booth's required format

Your MBA resume will be due to IBG and Career Services for our company-facing resume books shortly after school starts. There will be resources and programs to help you with your resume once you get to campus, but we strongly recommend that you get a head start on preparing your MBA resume this summer. [Complete the Resume Assignment in Canvas.](#)

Explore Wall Street Prep free, self-paced courses

If you have completed all of the aforementioned recommendations and are interested in familiarizing yourself with investment banking technical material, Wall Street Prep is a great resource that is free to current students and admitted students in June. Additional information on WSP is as follows:

- WSP has lots of self-paced video courses that cover a variety of finance topics. Most of them are broken up into bite sized videos that make the content easier to digest, which is why they've been a favorite prep resources of Boothies in the past
- You can set up a free Wall Street Prep account through Booth [here](#) once admits are granted access in June
- While there are lots of WSP courses, we believe the "Ultimate Guide to the Technical Finance Interview" course is the most directly applicable to IB recruiting

FAQs

What do Investment Bankers do? Essentially, investment bankers are financial advisors to corporations and, in some cases, to governments. They help their clients with a variety of activities, including raising money, evaluating potential acquisitions, and strategic restructurings. The Corporate Finance Institute provides a great overview of investment banking in their article titled [What do Investment Bankers Do?](#)

Can I recruit for IB if I don't have a finance background? Absolutely. A large portion of each year's class are "career switchers" with a variety of non-finance backgrounds including teaching, marketing, engineering, consulting, and military. IBG programming, resources, and mentorship will provide you with all of the behavioral and technical preparation necessary to succeed in IB recruiting. No finance background is necessary.

Do I have to live in New York to work in IB? Nope! Lots of Boothies successfully recruit for IB roles in cities other than New York every year, including but not limited to the following: Chicago, IL; San Francisco/Bay Area, CA; Charlotte, NC; Houston, TX; Minneapolis, MN.

Can I recruit for groups that don't align with my professional background (e.g., recruit for a technology group with a real estate background)? Yes. While having relevant industry experience will be an asset in the recruiting process, it is also possible for Boothies to pivot to groups that are not directly aligned with their professional backgrounds. That said, some industry groups are harder to break into. IBG and Career Services will help with your recruiting strategy.

What summer preparation do I need to do before getting to campus? We recommend you complete the [Career Services Canvas Course for the Class of 2028](#) this summer, prior to Orientation and Pre-term. We also strongly recommend you review the 2026 Admit FAQ in full posted on Canvas, which provides an in-depth guide to help students prepare for IB recruiting over the summer.

Should I start networking before recruiting begins in the fall? No, not with bankers. Absolutely do not add bankers on LinkedIn, cold message them, etc. This could negatively impact your IB recruiting process. You will have the time and framework to network once recruiting starts.

What is summer pre-MBA recruiting? Some banks offer pre-MBA/summer recruiting, which involves applying and interviewing for summer '27 internships this summer. While we recognize that a perceived benefit

of these programs is the opportunity to be done with recruiting before starting school, IBG strongly advises against partaking in these programs for a variety of reasons, including the following:

- Only a select subset of banks engage in summer recruiting, so your options will be fewer than what exists through Booth recruiting.
- If you participate in a bank's pre-MBA recruiting process and you receive an internship offer for summer '27, you will most likely be required to accept or decline before summer ends. If you accept the offer, you cannot participate in any fall recruiting activities. If you decline the offer, some banks will not be interested in seeing you again in the fall recruiting season.
- IBG does not provide guidance/training for pre-MBA summer recruiting, so in most cases, it will be more challenging to put your best foot forward this summer.
- Recruiting for a post-MBA job truly is a 2-year process that begins with internship recruiting in the fall of year 1 of the MBA. The internship recruiting process is about more than just getting a job – you will form lasting relationships with your peers, develop a broad network of alums across banks, and learn technical skills that will provide a helpful foundation in advance of your internship. These benefits will largely be missed by engaging in the summer recruiting process. Additionally, the network you build through internship recruiting is an asset post-internship, if you need to re-recruit for IB, and throughout your future career in banking.
- Career Services has information about [engaging with pre-MBA recruiting opportunities](#).

What kind of support does IBG provide? In summary, IBG will provide you with all the tools and mentorship to be successful through every phase of the recruiting process and beyond. We will provide a detailed overview of the IBG recruiting process during a kickoff meeting once you arrive to campus in the fall.

Once again, we can't wait to meet you all in the fall! It is important to complete the [Career Services Canvas Course for the Class of 2028](#) and review the 2026 Admit FAQ so you are ready for the next phase of career prep in Orientation and Pre-term.